

Stains of The Fear

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INT. STUDIO - NIGHT

We see a frame of a window and the door of an office, inside the office we see JONAS, a gaunt man in his late 30s, sitting at his desk working. After a moment he glances at his phone, hastily packs his things, and leaves the studio. He locks the door, runs off, and exits the frame. We hear his footsteps receding.

EXT. Hallway - NIGHT

Jonas returns, seen from inside the office, and pulls out a cigarette. As he flicks open his lighter, it slips from his hand and clatters to the lower floor.

Jonas exits the frame and heads downstairs to retrieve it. The window of the front office is now lit.

From the lower floor he looks up, amazed, then hurries back toward the office.

Re-entering the hallway, he finds the opposite apartment dark. He walks up to the door and knocks on it.

Jonas

Peter?

No response. He knocks. Still nothing. He pulls out his phone, takes a photo of the window, then calls Peter. No answer.

Jonas moves cautiously toward his studio. Unthinkingly, he pushes the door open—

He stops abruptly.

He had locked the door. But now, it's unlocked.

INT. STUDIO - NIGHT

Jonas Unthinkingly pushes the door open—

He stops abruptly.

He had locked the door. But now, it's unlocked. He enters, leaving the door slightly open. He scans the room. Everything seems normal. He shuts and locks the door.

Seated at his desk, he stares at the opposite apartment. The window across the way appears to be molding over.

Suddenly, a faint THUMP against his own window. He jolts awake—he had dozed off.

Looking out, he sees nothing unusual. He leans forward to check below—

No one is there.

He sits back down and slowly raises his eyes. The opposite apartment window is now lit again.

A SHADOWED FIGURE is staring at him.

A KNOCK at the studio door.

Jonas

Who's there?

Silence.

Another KNOCK. Louder.

Jonas (CONT'D) (shouting)

Who's there?!

Silence.

Then—a sound of retreating footsteps.

Jonas looks back to the opposite apartment—the window is still lit, but the figure is gone.

Then—a sudden rush of footsteps toward his door. A LOUD POUNDING.

Jonas stands, heart pounding.

Jonas (CONT'D)

What do you want?!

Silence.

The footsteps recede again.

Then—a CHARGE toward the door, a THUMP.

At the same time, his phone VIBRATES. He jolts awake.

Startled, he fumbles for it—Peter is calling.

Jonas (CONT'D) (into phone)

Peter?

Peter (V.O.)

Hey. Working late again?

Jonas

Huh?!

Peter (V.O.)

You called me?

Jonas

(trying to steady himself) Yeah... You here?

Peter (V.O.)

Where?

Jonas

Your office.

Peter (V.O.)

No, I'm home. Why?

Jonas (swallows hard)

Nothing. I was in the office. I heard something. I thought you might be here.

Peter (V.O.)

You still in the office?

Jonas

Yeah. Missed the tram.

Peter (V.O.)

So you staying till morning

Jonas

Yeah. No way back till morning.

Peter (V.O.)

Alright. Be careful.

A long pause.

Jonas

Why?

Peter (V.O.)

Yesterday, Andre told me about this place.
Apparently, squatters used to stay there.
(Unrecognizable noises) was empty for a while.

Jonas

One sec—signal's bad. Let me move.

He paces.

Peter (V.O.)

I mean, it's not the safest area. You know the kind
of people who live around there.

Jonas

Yeah, I know.

Peter (V.O.)

Let's do something. (A moment of silence) You hear
me?

Jonas

Yeah.

Peter (V.O.)

Listen, I'll come get you once Nina and the kids
get home.

Jonas

No need for that.

Peter (V.O.)

No! It's dangerous. Don't underestimate this.

Jonas

We have nothing worth stealing.

Peter (V.O.)

It's not about what we have. It's about the office itself.

Jonas

Okay, see you then.

Peter (V.O.)

See you. Keep your phone close.

After the call is cut off, Jonas goes to his desk and notices that the office across from him is now lit. He takes his camera out of his bag, assembles the tripod, mounts the camera on it, and points it toward the window of the office across the way before switching it on. We see him adjusting the camera's frame, then a close-up shot of the opposite window, which Jonas stares at for a while.

He places his hand on the shutter like a hunter ready to shoot. Suddenly, he notices something that looks like a ghostly shadow. He reacts instantly and snaps a photo. Lifting his head, he looks at the window—nothing there. He checks through the camera's view again—still nothing.

He turns back and checks the photo he's just taken, but the camera shows no image. He switches the camera off and on, removes and reinserts the memory card—still nothing. He then connects the camera to his laptop to see the photo. When he opens the file, he's surprised by what he sees: strange spots in the image that look like some kind of mold, vaguely similar to what he had been working on but still different.

At that moment, his phone rings. It's Peter.

Jonas (into phone)

Peter?

STATIC fills the line.

Jonas (CONT'D)

Hello?

Peter (V.O.) (Suddenly)

You hear me?

Jonas

Now yes.

Peter (V.O.)

Everything's okay?

Jonas

Yes... No, your office light is on.

Peter (V.O.)

Probably forgot to turn it off.

Jonas

It wasn't on before.

Peter (V.O.)

Maybe you imagined it.

Jonas

It wasn't on before. It turned on... off... then on again.

Peter (V.O.)

Can't understand what you're saying.

Jonas

I can take a photo and send it to you.

Peter (V.O.) (suspicious) (his tone changes)

You're taking photos?

Jonas hesitates.

Jonas

Not yet. Will send it to you.

Peter (V.O.) (softly) (in his previous tone)

Ah, okay. Look, I called to tell you that Nina has arrived. I'm on my way. Pack your things

Jonas

My things are packed.

Jonas zooms into the photo. Takes a closer look at the details of the distortions.

Peter (V.O.)

What do you see?

Jonas (shocked)

Huh?!

Peter (V.O.)

you heard me?

Jonas

Huh! Yeah. Call me when you arrive.

Peter (V.O.)

Take care!

Jonas stares at the photo for a while, then suddenly remembers something. He quickly opens the gallery on his phone and pulls up the last photo he took. He zooms in. A small mark appears in this photo as well, but in both images, there is no sign of another person.

He transfers the photo to his laptop for a closer look. Adjusting the image settings, he enhances the details, making the stain more visible. He places the two photos side by side—both contain the same mold-like spots.

Confused and unsettled, he pulls his gaze away from the laptop screen and stares at the window across from him.

A noise comes from the kitchen. Slowly, he walks toward it and reaches the doorway.

Suddenly, a shadow appears.

Jonas immediately slams the door shut.

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Jonas

Who's there?! What do you want?

There is no response.

Jonas locks the door and waits for a while. He presses his ear against it—silence. Slowly, he steps away from the door.

His phone rings. He turns back to the room to answer it. He picks up the call. It's Peter

Jonas (nervously)

Yes?

Peter (V.O.)

Don't be scared it'll only get worse.

Jonas

What?

Peter (V.O.)

Your condition. Fear can destroy you. Take a deep breath and go sit down in a chair.

Jonas hesitates briefly, goes to his office, and sits down. As soon as he sits, Peter begins to speak:

Peter (V.O.)

Alright, put your phone on speaker and place it on the table.

Jonas puts the phone on speaker and sets it on the table.

Peter (V.O.)

Okay, tell me what did you see?

Jonas

I didn't really see anything. Why are you asking these questions?

Peter (V.O.)

It's obvious you're scared. I want what's best for you. You're a good friend of mine.

Jonas stays silent.

Peter (V.O.)

Alright then, tell me now.

Jonas

I feel like there's someone in the office.

Peter (V.O.)

Didn't you lock the door?

Jonas hesitates before answering.

Jonas

Yeah.

Peter (V.O.)

Well...

Jonas (after a brief pause)

I locked the door, but I heard a noise from the kitchen.

Peter (V.O.)

Maybe it was the water faucet.

Jonas

I saw it.

Peter (V.O.)

What did it look like?

Jonas

A shadow.

We hear Peter take a deep breath and exhale heavily.

Peter (V.O.)

It's nothing. I'm on my way. My car was out of gas, so I had to fill up. I might be a bit late. Stay safe.

Jonas

I'll see you—

Mid-sentence, the call cuts off. Jonas looks back at his laptop screen, staring at it for a while. Then he goes over to the camera, studies its screen for a moment, and snaps a photo. He transfers the photo to the laptop; the same strange spots appear again. He takes another photo—same result. He does this once more. Finally, he gazes at the photos for a while, then lifts his head and looks at the window across from him. We see the shadow has reappeared. For a moment, the image seems moldy. He rubs his eyes, then looks at the shadow again. Slowly, he reaches for the camera and takes another picture. He checks it; it's dark. He brings up the ISO on his camera and then takes another picture. Still unclear. It's extremely dark with mold-like distortions. He repeats this process two more times; the last photo is brighter but heavily overrun with mold-like patterns, so much that nothing is recognisable.

Still staring at the opposite window, his phone rings. Without shifting his gaze, he answers:

Jonas

Have you arrived?

Peter (V.O.)

I'm close. Don't worry.

A moment of silence.

Peter (V.O.)

Not much farther now. You just have to wait a bit longer. (slight pause) Can you?

Jonas

Can I what?

Peter (V.O.)

Can you wait?

Jonas

I think so.

Peter (V.O.)

Is it still there?

Jonas

Yeah.

Peter (V.O.)

Can you feel it?

Jonas (more firmly)

Yes.

Peter takes a deep breath.

Jonas

Strongly.

Peter (V.O.)

What does it feel like?

Jonas

Fear.

Peter (V.O.)

What are you afraid of?

Jonas

The end.

Peter (V.O.)

The end isn't always bad. Is what you're seeing
right now scary?

Jonas (long pause)

No.

Peter (V.O.)

Then what do you see?

Jonas describes the moldy image.

Peter (V.O.)

No, I mean—what do you see?

Jonas (long pause)

The end.

The shadow fades from the window across the way, stepping out of
the frame. Soft footsteps approach until they reach us.

Peter (voice nearby)

Don't be afraid. I'm here.

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